Even through ‘a process of evaluation and a series of interviews or even based on reputation and past record’, it might not be possible to correctly assess their personalities, he said. It would also be difficult to predict how they would behave after their appointment, he added.

Soonawala drew the attention of the members to the note dated 15 September 2010, where he had talked about instances where ‘CEOs of well-known and large MNCs’ were removed ‘for various misdeeds even after many years in office’. Therefore, he opined that selecting an outsider ‘who has a high stature’ may not guarantee that they have ‘high values and integrity’. He strongly recommended B. Muthuraman, R. Gopalakrishnan, Ravi Kant, Prasad Menon and Noel Tata as possible candidates who could be considered by the committee. The committee, however, did not fully endorse Soonawala’s views on limiting the candidates to only insiders. It opined that several negative aspects had emerged even in the case of senior management within a group, although they had worked in such positions ‘for a long time’. Consequently, there was no advantage to barring outsiders.

Having reached an understanding on the criteria, the committee met several more times. Some of the biggest names in the corporate world were discussed. The headhunters Spencer Stuart’s London office, which had been engaged by the Tatas, suggested some names, and others came from the selection committee members.

A few foreigners were also initially considered. They included Sir John Rose, chief executive of Rolls-Royce, and John Thain, former CEO of Merrill Lynch. Krishna Kumar also met some others, including Indra Nooyi of PepsiCo. After a few months of deliberations, however, it was decided that it would be more prudent to consider only Indians. It was reasoned that those who did not have considerable experience in India would find it difficult to provide leadership in the socioeconomic environment of the country.

One of the more important deliberations of the committee was held on 23 March 2011. In this meeting Ishaat Hussain, Noel Tata, S. Ramadorai, R. Gopalakrishnan, B. Muthuraman and Ravi Kant were interviewed. But eight months after the search had begun, the committee was nowhere near finding a suitable candidate.

Zeroing in on Cyrus Mistry